

Holland-based humanitarian group, last year conducted a survey in two areas on the impact of the conflict. The results are frightening. Of 510 people interviewed, one in every 10 had lost one or more members of immediate family between 1989 and 2002, and one in three had lost members of their extended families. According to the survey, half of them felt occasionally safe and more than one-third have had "suicidal ideations".

Experts say that the breakdown of mental health is one of the most tragic effects of the conflict in Kashmir. It manifests itself in the form of post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), deprivation, emotional scars, stress, trauma, anxiety, depression and suicides. "The enormity and intensity of these psychological-psychiatric problems is evident by the fact that every family living in the Kashmir valley has developed one or more such problems," says Dr Bashir A. Dabla, head of Sociology Department at the University of Kashmir.

Violence has already pushed people to a threshold of a traumatic existence. They just need a trigger to go over that precipice. A shocking realisation among experts on mental health in Kashmir is

the shape of searches and interrogations by security forces in a north Kashmir village had made Manzoor Ahmed paranoid. One day Ahmed, as usual, was busy at his small shop near his village when soldiers roughed him up. That day Ahmed went home only to attempt the extreme step of ending his life by consuming some organophosphorus compound. As his condition deteriorated, his family members got suspicious and rushed him to the SMHS Hospital in Srinagar. Though his life was saved, doctors attending to him said that Ahmed had developed

tempts by students everyday in the immediate aftermath of board examination results. Also, with almost 2,50,000 unemployed literate youth, the suicidal tendencies are increasingly becoming a desperate way-out. There is a strong relationship between poor mental health and social deprivation. Experts say that individuals who live in areas with a high rate of unemployment are at a risk of developing mental problems, which finally result in suicidal thoughts.

DEATH WATCH: Relatives wait as a rescue team tries to fish out a body



42 people have committed

suicide in the state in the first five months of 2007.

that the uncertain situation here has

spawned a residual fear that is eating away at the vitals of the individual's self-confidence. The very confusion and precariousness of normal existence has made life seem doubly difficult. Setbacks, that can otherwise be taken in one's stride, are seen as insurmountable. So much so that the younger generation looks to be too keen to end it all, be it from suffering reverses in examinations, love life, marital discords or even sheer depression.

A very high percentage of respondents in the MSF survey pointed out humiliation and threat of violence as major reasons for their evaporating inner calm. The daily humiliation in

serious trauma and needed psychological treatment.

The environment in which a person lives has a direct impact on his or her mental health. A situation in which people encounter barriers to free movement and thought can very often lead to psychological pressures and disorders. "This has been like a volcanic build-up that is now exploding silently," says a psychiatrist at state's only Psychiatric Diseases Hospital in Srinagar. "It is a very typical scenario in most areas witnessing prolonged and ongoing conflict."

Adding to the already grim suicide scenario, local newspapers report nearly half a dozen cases of suicide at-

Sher-e-Kashmir Institute of Medical Sciences (SKIMS), the top tertiary healthcare centre in the state, does not have a psychiatry section. A lone, grossly under-equipped and understaffed psychiatric hospital in Kashmir demonstrates the amount of attention mental health receives in the state. More than 40,000 patients with varying degrees of mental illnesses visiting the hospital every year since 1998 perhaps need to unite into a votebank to receive the attention, a problem of this magnitude deserves. With a spurt in suicide cases in the last couple of years, one thing is certain: it is certainly not a matter to be ignored.